

FrameGrade.

The 2026 Premium Frontend Pass — Full Walkthrough

How the frontend was rebuilt from a two-palette accretion into a single-source, mechanically-guarded design system — and why every value in it is the way it is.

Project	Stack	Type	Status
FrameGrade (street-story-curator/frontend)	React 18 · TypeScript · Vite · Tailwind 3 · Tauri 2	Design-system overhaul	● Verified — lint, tsc, build

01 What changed, in one page

The frontend reached its old state by accretion: **539 inline style blocks**, **15 font sizes**, **13 border radii**, **41 stray hex colours**, and **two live palettes at once** — a blue-black one in `App.tsx` and a neutral one in `tokens.css`, fighting over the same pixels. Roughly 98% of controls did not react to the cursor at all, because inline styles cannot express `:hover`. That accumulation is what read as "dated" — not any single bad screen.

The premium pass replaced accretion with a system:

LAYER	BEFORE	AFTER
Colour	41 stray hex values, two competing palettes	One token file; a token linter fails the build on any hex outside it
Type	15 ad-hoc font sizes	5-step scale + display role; Geist / Geist Mono, tabular numerals everywhere
Depth	Flat panels, no elevation logic	3-step pure-black shadow ramp + translucent glass chrome
Interaction	~98% of controls inert	One Button primitive; hover/focus/press defined once
Welcome screen	Plain flat card	Hero with brand mark, feature strip, inverted-ink CTA, ambient glow
Guardrails	None	<code>lint:tokens</code> + <code>lint:tdz</code> run inside <code>npm run build</code>

The governing rule: chrome and text are dead neutral (R = G = B). Machine judgements are cold or absent. Warm colour — the grease-pencil orange — appears **only** where the photographer put it: his stars, his selects, his rejects. A tool whose job is judging light may not tint its own chrome.

02 The token system — single source of truth

`src/theme/tokens.css` is the **only** file permitted to contain a raw hex or raw px size. Tailwind's config maps every utility (`bg-surface`, `text-ink-2`, `rounded-md` ...) to a custom property, so runtime values flow through the same names — and the linter keeps it that way mechanically.

Ground ramp — strictly neutral, re-stepped for depth

TOKEN	VALUE	ROLE
 <code>--well</code>	#080808	Loupe stage, image backdrop — the one place near-black is correct
 <code>--ground</code>	#141414	App background, gallery field
 <code>--surface</code>	#1d1d1d	Panels, header, filmstrip rail, modals
 <code>--raised</code>	#282828	Controls, inputs, chips
 <code>--raised-hover</code>	#333333	THE hover token — +11 luminance, unmistakable under the cursor
 <code>--line</code> / <code>--line-strong</code>	#262626 / #3f3f3f	Hairline dividers / panel edges, active borders

Ink ramp

TOKEN	VALUE	NOTES
<code>--ink</code>	#f5f5f5	16.4:1 vs ground — primary text, lifted for crispness on the deepened ground
<code>--ink-2</code>	#b4b4b4	Body copy, secondary labels
<code>--ink-3</code>	4.1:1	Section eyebrows, hints — survives the darker surfaces

The only non-neutral colours in the entire app

TOKEN	VALUE	RESERVATION
 <code>--mark</code>	#e0592f	Grease pencil — the photographer's own judgements ONLY. Never on focus rings, active tabs, primary buttons, or progress fills
 <code>--grade-strong</code>	#48b89c	Teal — instrument reading, not a success toast
 <code>--alarm-crit</code> /  <code>--alarm-warn</code>	#c4452f / #c8862a	Status chrome only, when something actually needs the user

Type, radius, motion

SCALE	STEPS	NOTES
Type	11 / 13 / 16 / 20 / 30 / 40 px	<code>.t-label</code> (600, uppercase, +.08em) · <code>.t-num</code> (mono, tabular, slashed zero) · <code>.t-display</code> (40px, −0.02em)
Radius	3 px / 8 px / 50%	Cells & buttons / modals & pills / circles. There is no fourth radius.
Motion	120 / 220 ms · cubic-bezier(.2,0,0,1)	One curve, two durations. Never transition layout properties on elements holding a photograph.
Elevation	<code>--shadow-1/2/3</code>	Pure black only; shadow-3 carries a hairline top-light edge so panels don't melt into the ground

03 The welcome hero — anatomy of the redesign

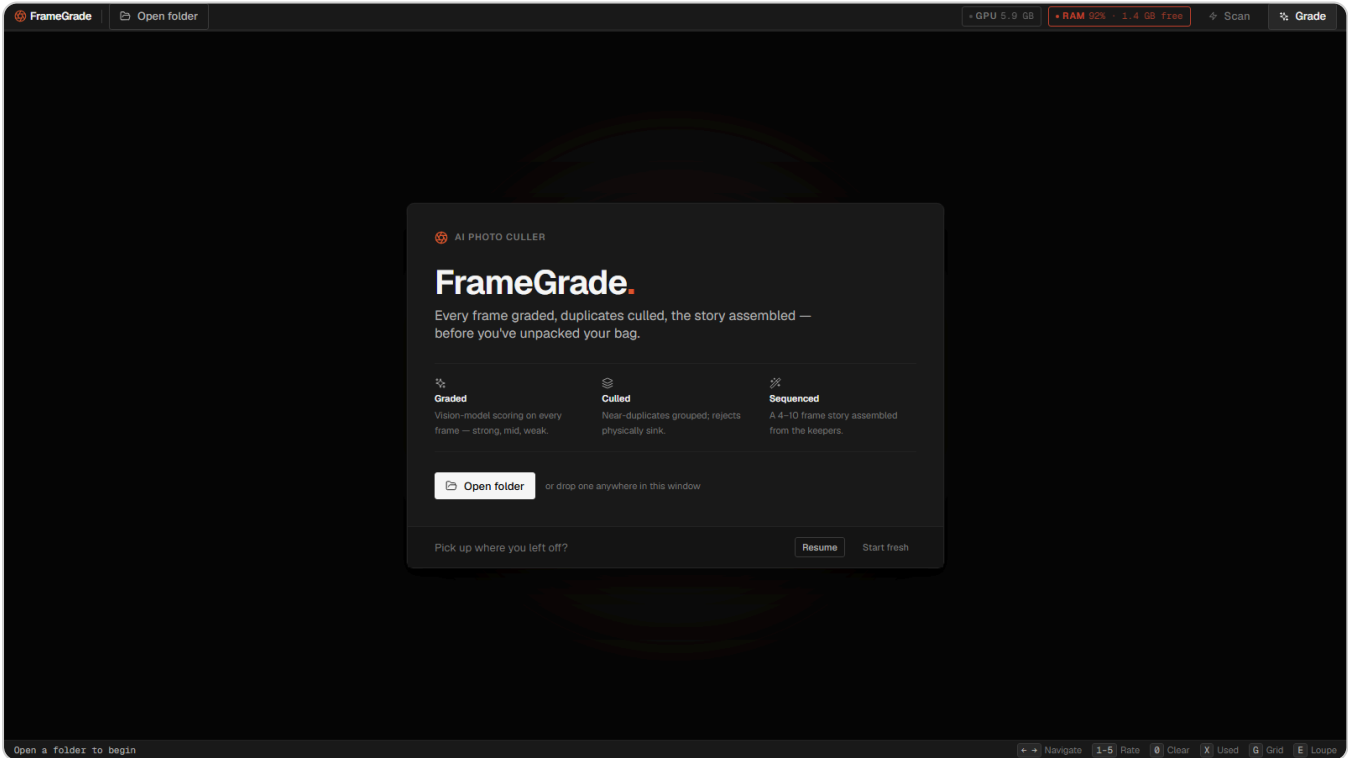
The welcome screen is the app's first impression and its only photograph-free surface — which makes it the one place the warm mark colour may breathe as ambience.

BEFORE

Flat grey card floating on flat black. Version chip, one outline button, no hierarchy beyond size. Nothing reacted to the cursor.

AFTER

Elev-3 card with top-light hairline edge, aperture-mark brand row, display headline with a mark-coloured full stop, three-verb feature strip between hairlines, inverted-ink CTA, resume strip on ground, two soft ambient glows behind.



Live render, localhost:5173 — headless-Chrome capture after the ink-CTA pass.

Design decisions worth naming

- **The full stop is the signature.** `FrameGrade.` — small, confident, and the only warm glyph on the entire stage.
- **Three verbs, not three paragraphs.** Graded / Culled / Sequenced — the product described in six words of body copy, separated by hairlines rather than cards-in-cards.
- **Ambient glows stay hue-safe.** A `--mark-dim` radial (15% tint, 48px blur) over a raised-grey radial — present depth, zero contamination, and always behind the card, never behind photographs.
- **The resume strip is honest chrome.** Ground-coloured, hairline-separated; session continuity ("Pick up where you left off?") is a first-class citizen of the layout, not a toast.
- **Entrance is one motion.** A single `dialogIn` rise-and-settle on the shared 220ms curve — no staggered children, no bounce.

04 The button system — and the new `ink` variant

One primitive, `src/components/ui/Button.tsx`, owns hover, focus, press and disabled states once. Deliberately absent: an accent-coloured primary. Emphasis is carried by **luminance and border weight**, never hue.

VARIANT	RECIPE	USED FOR
<code>default</code>	Transparent + line-strong border, <code>ink-2</code> label	Toolbar actions
<code>quiet</code>	No border, <code>ink-3</code> label	Dense clusters where borders would add noise
<code>solid</code>	Raised fill + line-strong border	Emphasised actions (header "Grade")
<code>ink</code> ★ new	<code>bg-ink text-well</code> — inverted, full-luminance white fill	The ONE primary action on a screen (hero "Open folder")
<code>danger</code>	Neutral until hover, then alarm-crit border/label	Destructive actions

```
// The 2026 addition – strongest step the chrome may take, still strictly neutral.  
ink: 'bg-ink border border-ink text-well hover:opacity-90 active:opacity-85',
```

Why inverted ink instead of a coloured primary: on a dark, neutral tool, a *white* button is the highest-contrast statement available — the Linear/Vercel pattern — and it cannot leak warmth into photo judgement. Hover dims the fill (opacity) rather than swapping tokens, so the inversion survives the cursor; `active:scale(.98)` gives press feedback without layout cost.

05 Guardrails — how this stays premium

- `npm run lint:tokens` — fails the build on any raw hex or bare `fontSize:` in managed code. Legacy literals are baselined at 0. This is the point: only a mechanical check keeps 41 stray hexes

from drifting back.

- `npm run lint:tdz` — temporal-dead-zone check; the token refactor moved declarations, and this class of bug is now mechanical to catch.
- **Keyframes live in `index.css`, not the Tailwind config** — Tailwind only emits `@keyframes` it can see referenced by utilities in source, so config-only keyframes silently killed 11 spinners and every skeleton. Plain-CSS declaration makes emission unconditional; the linter enforces the pairing.
- **Reduced-motion policy** — opacity fades (they carry the Weak/reject meaning) survive; every transform is dropped.
- **Focus is neutral, two-ring** — light outer + dark inset, so the indicator survives both on chrome and on top of a blown highlight in a photograph.
- **Scrollbars and range inputs are themed** — native OS controls read as foreign objects in a custom dark UI, so they're rebuilt on the token scale.

06 Verification — what was actually run

CHECK	COMMAND	RESULT
Token guard	<code>npm run lint:tokens</code>	PASS — managed code clean, legacy literals 0 (baseline 0)
Type check	<code>tsc --noEmit</code>	PASS
TDZ guard	<code>npm run lint:tdz</code>	PASS (runs inside build)
Production build	<code>npm run build</code>	PASS — 423.67 kB JS (135.49 gzip) · 26.70 kB CSS · <code>dist/</code> regenerated
Visual	Headless-Chrome capture of <code>localhost:5173</code>	PASS — hero renders with inverted-ink CTA (<code>cdp-shots/hero_ink_cta.png</code>)

File map

FILE	ROLE
src/theme/tokens.css	Every colour, size, radius, shadow, duration — the only place a literal lives
src/theme/tokens.ts	T.* runtime accessor returning var(--x)
tailwind.config.js	Maps utilities to tokens; defaults replaced, not extended
src/index.css	Elevation/glass utilities, keyframes, scrollbars, range inputs, focus rings
src/components/ui/Button.tsx	The single button primitive (5 variants incl. ink)
src/App.tsx · welcome hero	Brand row, display headline, feature strip, ink CTA, resume strip (~line 2900)
scripts/lint-tokens.mjs · check-tdz.mjs	The mechanical guardrails wired into npm run build

To run it: cd street-story-curator/frontend && npm run dev:full — Vite on :5173 with the Python API alongside. npm run build re-ships dist/ for the Tauri shell; npm run tauri:build packages the desktop app.